

Black Crappie

Find the school, then hold the depth

Pomoxis nigromaculatus

Recognize it

Deep, compressed silver-olive panfish with irregular dark speckles scattered across the sides.

Body	Seven or eight dorsal spines; mottling has no orderly vertical bars.
Mouth/fins	Large upturned mouth; dorsal and anal fins are nearly equal in outline.
Confusion	White crappie usually shows vertical bars and five or six dorsal spines.

Lake role

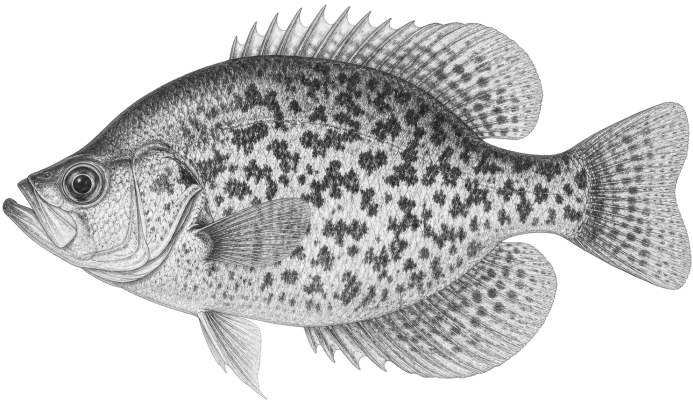
Where it belongs

Clear-water weeds, wood, basin edges, and suspended schools near prey.

Food and season

Insects and small fish; shallow near spawning cover, then edge or suspend.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected new weeds in spring; later scan outside weed edges and open-water prey.
North	Test wood, weed pockets, and the first break near protected spawning water.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

1. **Slip float.** Hang a small jig or live bait just above marked fish; adjust depth before changing color.
2. **Slow vertical jig.** Use a light plastic or hair jig and pause; keep it above the school.
3. **Stop rule.** If no marks, bites, or bait appear in ten minutes, move and search rather than decorating empty water.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Use wet hands and a small rubber net. Support the body; do not lift a large fish by the lip alone.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Prefer abundant hand-size fish; release unusually large adults if a meal is already secured.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Black Crappie. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.